Letters to a Student Revolutionary

By Elizabeth Wong

BIBI: *(to audience).* I was touring China with Mom and Dad. I took to the streets of Beijing. Wandered into Tiananmen Square-a hungry look in my eyes, a vain hope in my heart. No place is truly civilized without Mickey D and a drive-up window.

CHORUS: *(to audience).* Summer 1979. Tourism was still so new in China.

KAREN: (*enters, pushing an old coaster bicycle -- to audience).* I am on my way home from the factory. End of the graveyard shift. It is already hot like hell. Do I say that right? Yes, I think so. What harm is there to practice a little English?

BIBI: *(to audience).* Oh look. Grandmothers with ancient faces, pushing bamboo strollers like shopping carts. *(She peeks into the strollers.)* Ahhhhh, sweetest little babies with wispy, fuzzy, spiky hair.

KAREN: *(to audience).* I will go up to her and speak to her. We will make beautiful sentences together.

INTRODUCTION

Two young women . . . worlds apart in culture forge a friendship that lasts throughout the years. Who would have guessed that a chance meeting would lead to a long-distance bond that in a very small way could bring the cultures of Asia and the U.S. to a greater understanding of one another.

Letters to a Student Revolutionary by Elizabeth Wong

KAREN: Hello.

BIBI: Oh, hello.

KAREN: Please. Not so loud. *(Beat.)* Are you?

BIBI: *(whispers).* I am. How can you tell?

KAREN: Ahh. *(Pause.)* Your hair.

BIBI: Completely unnatural, I know. It's called a permanent. Every time I go to the salon, they want to give me the same old, tired thing-the classic bob and bangs, *exactly* like yours.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

They tell me, "You look so cute. A little China doll, that's what you are." So I say, "Aldo, baby darling, perm it. Wave it. Frizz it. Spike it. Color it blue." It's unusual, don't you think?

KAREN: *(starts to touch BIBI's sleeve; then withdraws shyly).* Here we have only a few colors. Grey and blue and green. May I ask what is your name?

BIBI: Bibi. My name is Bibi. *(They reach to shake hands. but before they touch, BIBI and KAREN freeze. (to audience).* Our conversation lasted about two, three minutes, tops. *(The two women move away from each other. BIBI shouts.)* That's Los Angeles, California. U.S.A. 90026. Can you remember all of that?

KAREN: *(nods vigorously. To self).* Yes, I will remember.

BIBI: *(to audience).* She didn't even tell me her name.

CHORUS: Bibi went back home to California, U.S.A. And that was the beginning of a most *un-comfortable* correspondence.

KAREN: *(writes).* Summer, 1979. My dear American friend ... *(Scratches out, starts again.)* My dear new friend. Greetings from Beijing. *(KAREN sits back, stares into space.)* . . . I met you in Tiananmen Square. It is a happy feeling I have . . . to have you for a secret friend, a special friend. I have much stupidity since I realized I never told you my name.

BIBI: *(to KAREN).* Karen? Karen is a good name.

KAREN: *(To audience.)* I chose my new name in secret. Where you live, you can be open about such matters. But here we must do everything in secret. Bibi, you have such freedom. I have no freedom. None whatsoever. I was meant to be born in the United States, to live in freedom like you. Do you understand? *(Beat.)* Two days after I met you, my boss at the factory where I am in the accounting department, asked to speak to me. I am taken to a small room in the basement. This is *not* a good sign.

BOSS: *(kindly, as if to an errant child).* You were seen talking to an American. Now, don't be afraid. You may talk to Westerners now. But you must not listen to what they say. You must not get any ideas. *(Recites by rote.)* Good citizens have only ideas that also belong to The State. The *State is your mother.* The *State is your father.* The *State is more* than your mother or your father. Do you understand?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

KAREN: I said, "Yes." But in my heart, I do not understand. I have never understood why I cannot speak my opinions. *(Resignedly.)* But this is China. *(Beat.)* I think, Bibi, I want to be having freedom like you. Perhaps you, Bibi, will pay $10,000 for my airplane ticket and my living in California. I will work and work and work and pay you back. I look forward to your favorable response. Your friend, Karen.

BIBI: She's nothing to me and I'm nothing to her. I could care less. I'm not political. And I resent that she is trying to make me responsible for her freedom. I'm barely responsible for my own. *(Beat.)* January, 1980. Dear Karen, I am so sorry it's taken me nearly six months to write you back. *(To audience, resolutely.)* I would have answered you sooner, but I was unsure about how to respond to your letter . . . Karen. I don't know what possessed me. But two months ago, I did go to the office of the Immigration and Naturalization Service.

KAREN: Bibi, did you talk about me? Will you help me, Bibi?

BIBI: Karen, the government told me I was *not* a suitable sponsor. To be a sponsor, I have to prove I can support you as well as myself. Karen, I'm just starting out in life. I don't have much in the way of money.

KAREN: So when you are rich, you can sponsor me, yes?

BIBI: Karen, I really don't think I can do more. I mean, I don't even know you. I'm sorry. Sincerely, Bibi.

CHORUS: Karen continued to write to Bibi. Long letters about her life in China. Her longings for America. [She] would bring up the subject every now and then. Bibi tried to ignore [it], but finally got fed up.

BIBI: Winter, 1980. Dear Karen, You may ask me if you wish. But please do not bring my parents into this. They are not rich. The streets here are not paved with gold. They are paved with concrete, sweat, hard work and struggle. My mother and father struggle every day.

KAREN: Spring, 1981 . . . You asked about my mother. My mother is dead.

BIBI: When did she die?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

KAREN: When I was very young. Near my house, next to the pig pen, there is a rice field. *(Pause.)* My mother is in the field. I see her. *(Waves.)* MaMa! *"Bao Bao gay ni dai fan lail"* [Your baby brings you your lunch.] *(Beat.)* Wait! Who is that? It is the commissaire! -- the man who reports everything.

BIBI: I see him.

KAREN: He is shaking my mother. Why is he doing that? Where is he taking her? MaMa! MaMa! *(Pause.)* I just watched my mother as they took her away.

BIBI: I'm sorry.

KAREN: The cat eats the mouse. He doesn't apologize for doing what is in his nature to do. She was punished. Not for stealing, but for resisting. If the mouse struggles, the cat grips tighter, first with one paw, then with two. The only thing the mouse can do is escape, run away. *As* fast as you can. If you can. Public execution is part of our daily lives, part of our education process.

CHORUS: Bibi and Karen continued their correspondence, but sporadically. About once or twice a year.

BIBI: *(to audience).* Fall, 1986. Mmmm. *(Beat.)* You know what, Karen? Sometimes, I wish someone would tell me: This is what you are good at, Bibi, so go and do it. This is the man who is good for you, Bibi, marry him.

KAREN: You wouldn't listen anyway, and you know it.

BIBI: No, I probably wouldn't. *(To KAREN.)* How is . . . ?

KAREN: Lu Yan? Lu Yan is the only guy I've ever . . . how you say? . . .

BIBI: Slept with?

KAREN: No . . . he is the first man I ever dated. Not much choice here in China, even though we are very many millions of people.

BIBI: Choice! Talk about choice. Shall I regale you with tales from the darkside? Dates from hell? By my calculations, I would say I've met a total of, or had a disastrous dinner or ahem, et cetera, et cetera, with at least 127 men of assorted shapes and sizes and denominations. And colors. Don't forget colors.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

KAREN: I am getting married during the Mid-Autumn Festival. I'm not sure I want to be married . . . I want to do and see so much, but my world is so small.

BIBI: Here in America, we are free, free to choose our lovers and make our own mistakes. The most wonderful thing about freedom, Karen, is you get plenty of rope with which to hang yourself. Wait! Did you say getting married? How wonderful. It is wonderful, right?

CHORUS: Lu Yan and Karen were married in the fall of 1986. Karen's father and brother gave as a dowry to Lu Yan's family, two live chickens, eight kilos of pig's intestines, 500 steamed buns, a sea lion bicycle, 20 kilos of fish, and 10 cartons of American cigarettes.

KAREN: Winter, 1987. Dear Bibi, Lu Yan is always telling me what to do. Married life isn't what I thought. His mother tells me how to wash his shirts, how to make a dinner. She complains I do not concentrate, as my head is always spinning in the clouds. I do not know who I am.

BIBI: Spring, 1988. Dear Karen, I have changed newspapers five times in the past three years. It's easier to move up by moving out, but I'm getting a little tired of moving around. West Coast, East Coast. No place feels like home. Home doesn't even feel like home. Everywhere I go, I ask myself the question, "Who am I?" "How do I fit in?" The answer changes as fast as my address.

KAREN: Summer, 1988. Dear Bibi, I am a flower that will never open, never to be kissed by a bee. I want to open. I want to feel the sting of freedom. More and more, I feel bitter towards my life and my uselessness. I go to work, I have ideas to improve my job, and no one listens to me. I am a nobody. And I want to be a somebody.

BIBI: *(to KAREN).* Do you realize, Karen, we've been friends for almost ten years?

KAREN: And for ten years, you have not listened to one word I have said. I thought my marriage would make a solution, but it doesn't. It is not what I wanted for my life. Bibi, you know my heart. But you won't help me. I want to count for something. I can count for something in California.

BIBI: *(sincerely).* Here or there, your struggle is my struggle. No matter where we are, the struggle is the same. I'm trying not to run away from my problems. Why can't you be happy where you are?

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

KAREN: Why can't you? You live in a democracy, the individual can vote. You can count for something.

BIBI: What elementary school book did you read that from? My vote counts?

KAREN: That's right. You have the luxury to be selfish. To think of only yourself. You live in Paradise, and I live in hell.

BIBI: Well, Karen, it can be *hell* living in *Paradise.*

KAREN: *(ignoring).* I want democracy. Democracy for me. Freedom of speech. Freedom to chose. *(Short pause.)*

BIBI: Freedom to be confused. *(Beat.)*

KAREN: At least you have incentives to strive for a better life. But here whether I work one hour or ten hours, it's all the same. You just don't know what it's like.

BIBI: Can I help it if good ideals are polluted by extremists and dictators? Health care for everybody. Jobs for everybody. Everyone EQUAL under the law. Everyone working towards the greater good. And here's a novel concept people actually caring about the well-being of other people. In America, we call that welfare, and anyone on it is seen as a slackard and a mooch. In China, it's called social responsibility.

KAREN: If you think China is so good, you should come and live here. Bibi, I think you must be a communist at heart.

BIBI: Karen, I just can't afford anything right now. I'm unemployed-again. I quit. And I'm glad I did. I had names, addresses, quotes. And the paper wouldn't print it. We're having an election here, Karen, and an African-American is on the ballot. Quote, "I'd never put a black man in office." Quote: "No negro is going to run this country." Next morning, I read the paper, the quotes are gone. So, I storm into the managing editor's office during a budget meeting. Everybody was there. I said, "Hey what is this?" Why are you sanitizing the news, making it all pretty and clean for public consumption? I strenuously object. I have been so naive. So, in short, Karen, I quit.

KAREN: How lucky you are. You get to live your own life, your way.

BIBI: Sure I'm lucky. I get to fight my battles alone and unsupported, at work and at home. I'm a

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

lone wolf howling, and no one listens.

KAREN: Bibi, I have been thinking about what you say about America. And I think you are right. You see, Bibi, my country is changing and I have a new hope for a better life. And, I no longer wish to come to be an American like you. *(Beat.)* But I will always be your friend . . . *(to audience).* May, 1989. Dear Bibi, Here I am sitting in a tent in Tiananmen Square. For the first time in my life, I believe I can be a somebody, I believe my contribution will make a difference. I believe freedom will not grow out of theory but out of ourselves. We are fighting for a system that will respect the individual. The government must listen to us. All we want is a dialogue. A conversation. We want an end to censorship. We want an end to corruption. We are the voices of tomorrow. And our voices will be heard.

BIBI: May, 1989. Dear Karen, I've been watching the television reports. Everybody always asks me how I feel about what is happening in China. I'm so envious of your power-of how you have caused your government, caused the world to take notice. But I am also concerned about your naiveté in striving towards a foreign ideal. I do believe change will come, but it must be at your own pace. I am not sure America is the proper model for the new China that you want. Perhaps you should look to make a Chinese democracy. Karen, are you listening? Because right now, I think that to be a somebody in China is suicide. I don't mean to dampen your spirits, but I am worried. Please, please be careful.

KAREN: We are lying on the floor. Students on a hunger strike. Most of us are women. We haven't eaten in days, and I will not until I have my freedom. A clean division between what we want and what the government stands for. A clear break. On June 4, 1989. Tanks, armored personnel carriers and trucks full of troops marched into Tiananmen Square. Many of us linked arms, and tried to stand in their way.

SOLDIER: Be a good Chinese and go home. Go home and save your life. This is China. This is not the West. Be a good Chinese and go home.

KAREN: Tanks marched forward and crushed the first row. We marched forward. Run! Get out of the way. Run! Blood everywhere.

SOLDIER: Soldiers, forward. Students, comrades! Be good Chinese and go home. This is China.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

This is not the West.

KAREN: The statue fell. Everyone was running. *(screams).* You animals! *(lights out.)*

TRANSITION

*This year, *Insert Year*, is the _____ anniversary of the Tiananmen Square protests. And even today, the Chinese government continues to detain suspected activists and take measures to censor any mention of the event on the Internet.*

BIBI: On that day, as I watched the news, as world events marched into my living room. For the first time in my life, I knew . . . I felt . . . Chinese. And as days passed, I searched my TV set, changing channels, looking for news reports. Nothing, nothing coming out of China. Just a black curtain of silence.

CHORUS: Statistics on the death toll have been confusing. The Chinese Government says less than 400 people were killed, and only 23 of them were students. But according to *unofficial* reports, at least 5,000 died, and at least 30,000 people were reportedly injured. And China and America have begun a policy of selective historical amnesia.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Elizabeth Wong
ISBN: 978-0871296450
Publisher: Dramatic Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Jan 1996

AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY